 **Benefits**

According to the Supreme Court, the benefits under Lok Adalat are as follows[3]:

1. There is no court fee and if court fee is already paid the amount will be refunded if the dispute is settled at Lok Adalat.

2. The basic features of Lok Adalat are the procedural f lexibility and speedy trial of the disputes. There is no strict application of procedural laws like the Civil Procedure Code and the Evidence Act while assessing the claim by Lok Adalat.

3. The parties to the dispute can directly interact with the judge through their counsel which is not possible in regular courts of law.

4. The award by the Lok Adalat is binding on the parties and it has the status of a decree of a civil court and it is non-appealable, which does not cause the delay in the settlement of disputes finally.

In view of above facilities provided by the Act, Lok Adalats are boon to the litigating public as they can get their disputes settled fast and free of cost amicably.

The Law Commission of India summarized the advantages of the ADR (Alternative Dispute Resolution) in the following way[4]:

1. It is less expensive.

2. It is less time-consuming.

3. It is free from technicalities vis-à-vis conducting of cases in law courts.

4. Parties are free to discuss their differences of opinion without any fear of disclosure before any law courts.

5. Parties have the feeling that there is no losing or winning side between them but at the same time their grievance is redressed and their relationship is restored.

PERMANENT LOK ADALATS

The Legal Services Authorities Act, 1987 was amended in 2002 to provide for the establishment of the Permanent Lok Adalats to deal with cases pertaining to the public utility services.

The salient features of the new institution of Permanent Lok Adalats are as follows:

1. The Permanent Lok Adalat shall consist of a Chairman who is or has been a district judge or additional district judge or has held judicial office higher in rank than that of the district judge and two other persons having adequate experience in public utility services.

2. The Permanent Lok Adalat shall exercise jurisdiction in respect of one or more public utility services such as transport services of passengers or goods by air, road and water; postal, telegraph or telephone services; supply of power, light or water to the public by any